the East India Company (EICo), who in 1639 bought an unprofitable 3-mile strip of the Coromandel coast from a local Nayak ruler and 'improved' the local name of *nari medu*, or 'jackal's mound', into Madras.[8] Since Day and his fellow traders were themselves viewed locally as unclean and without caste they were obliged to employ local Paraiyars as their servants, since Paraiyars had no caste to be polluted. One of the earliest accounts of British travellers in India, published in 1613, describes them as 'the abhorred Piriawes', who acted as public executioners and were considered 'the basest, most stinking, ill-favoured people'.[9]

Yet even the Paraiyars regarded themselves as socially superior to those whose status was so low as to be right off the social scale altogether, as Caldwell describes:

> Though the Pareiyas themselves will admit that they belong – or, as they would prefer to say, that they belong at present – to the lowest division of castes … they are, equally with the higher castes, filled with that compound of pride of birth, exclusiveness, and jealousy, called 'caste feeling'. Whenever they have an opportunity, the Pareiyas deal out the very same treatment to other castes which are inferior to them.

But Caldwell was wrong in speaking of 'other castes', for these were more properly those without caste rather than outcaste. In his *History of Tinnevelly* Caldwell describes them peremptorily as 'the rude, black aborigines'. For the most part, these were forest-dwellers, living their own lives outside society in small, isolated jungle or mountain communities.

On two of those extraordinary edict rocks inscribed by order of the great emperor Ashoka in central and south Odisha in about 258 BCE, we find him warning the peoples on the southern borders of his newly conquered territory to behave themselves. He terms them 'Atavikas', or 'forest-